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IGB 101: Introduction to Igbo Language and Culture - Sounds, Grammar and Worldview

A structured start for students studying Igbo for the first time

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Igbo, African & Asian Studies | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Students entering Igbo studies vary from native speakers to complete beginners. This pack sets out the sound system, tone, noun classes and basic sentence patterns, and connects language to Igbo worldview through proverbs, naming and festivals, with drills that suit both groups.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Recognise and produce Igbo vowels, consonants, digraphs and nasal sounds.
- Use tone marks and explain how tone changes meaning.
- Identify noun classes and form simple sentences with correct agreement.
- Interpret proverbs and naming practices as expressions of cultural values.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Sounds and spelling

Igbo is written with the Latin alphabet adapted to its own sounds, including dotted vowels and digraphs.

- Eight vowels: a, e, i, i with dot, o, o with dot, u, u with dot.
- Consonant digraphs: ch, gb, gh, gw, kw, nw, ny, sh.
- The letter n can be syllabic, as in the word for and.
- Tone marks: high, low and, in some analyses, downstep.
- Minimal pairs distinguished only by tone show why tone must be written.
- Read aloud daily; Igbo orthography becomes intuitive with practice.

> **Tone is not decoration**
> Words such as isi can mean head, smell or a form of the verb depending on tone. Omitting tone marks creates real ambiguity in writing.

Grammar basics

Igbo grammar is regular in many ways, but it uses patterns that English speakers must learn explicitly.

- Nouns are grouped by prefixes such as o, a, e, i, n and m.
- Verbs carry subject agreement and aspect rather than tense in the English sense.
- Word order is subject, verb, object in simple declarative sentences.
- Questions can be formed with tone and with question particles.
- Possession uses a possessive pronoun that agrees with the noun class.
- Practice short sentences rather than memorising long paradigms.

Culture, proverb and worldview

Language carries culture; Igbo proverbs are compressed arguments about life.

- Proverbs are used in formal speech, adjudication and storytelling to persuade and to soften criticism.
- Names often encode circumstance, hope or gratitude, so naming is a form of communication.
- Festivals such as the New Yam Festival express gratitude and social hierarchy.
- Respect is encoded in address forms and titles.
- Oral literature includes folktales, praise poetry and riddles with pedagogical purposes.
- Colonial and missionary history shaped orthography and influenced language policy.

> **Use proverbs accurately**
> In assignments, explain a proverb's literal meaning, then its application. A proverb dropped without explanation earns no marks.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name the eight Igbo vowels.

Answer: a, e, i, i (with dot), o, o (with dot), u, u (with dot).

2. Why are tone marks important in written Igbo?

Answer: Tone distinguishes otherwise identical words, so omitting tone marks can change meaning.

3. Identify three Igbo consonant digraphs.

Answer: gb, ch and nw are three; kw, gw, ny, sh and gh are others.

4. What is the basic word order of a simple Igbo sentence?

Answer: Subject, verb, object.

5. Explain one function of proverbs in Igbo society.

Answer: Proverbs compress shared wisdom and are used to persuade, counsel or criticise indirectly in formal speech.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write the Igbo alphabet and mark the dotted vowels.
- [ ] Practise ten minimal pairs distinguished by tone.
- [ ] Build five simple sentences with correct verb agreement.
- [ ] Learn five proverbs, their literal meaning and one application each.
- [ ] Collect five Igbo names and explain their meanings.
- [ ] Read one page of Igbo aloud daily for a week.
- [ ] Record yourself speaking and ask a fluent speaker for feedback.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: